

29.5 THE THIRD CONDITIONAL

The third conditional, also called the “past unreal” conditional, is used to describe unreal situations in the past. It is often used to express regret about the past because the hypothetical situation that it describes is now impossible as a consequence of another past action.



UNREAL PAST SITUATION

UNREAL PAST RESULT

If we had left earlier, we would have caught the train.

↖ This didn't happen.

↖ So this didn't happen either.

FURTHER EXAMPLES



If I had woken up on time, I would have done my hair.



If you had been wearing a coat, you might have stayed warm.

↖ “Might” means this possibly would have happened.



If I had studied harder, I could have been a doctor.

↖ “Could” means this possibly would have happened.



If I had known it was your birthday, I would have bought you a present.

HOW TO FORM

“IF”

“HAD” + PAST PARTICIPLE

“WOULD / COULD / MIGHT”

“HAVE” + PAST PARTICIPLE

If

we had left earlier

, we would

have caught the train.

↖ The “if” clause is the unreal past condition.

↖ Using different modals changes the certainty of the imagined result.

↖ The conditional clause is the unreal result.